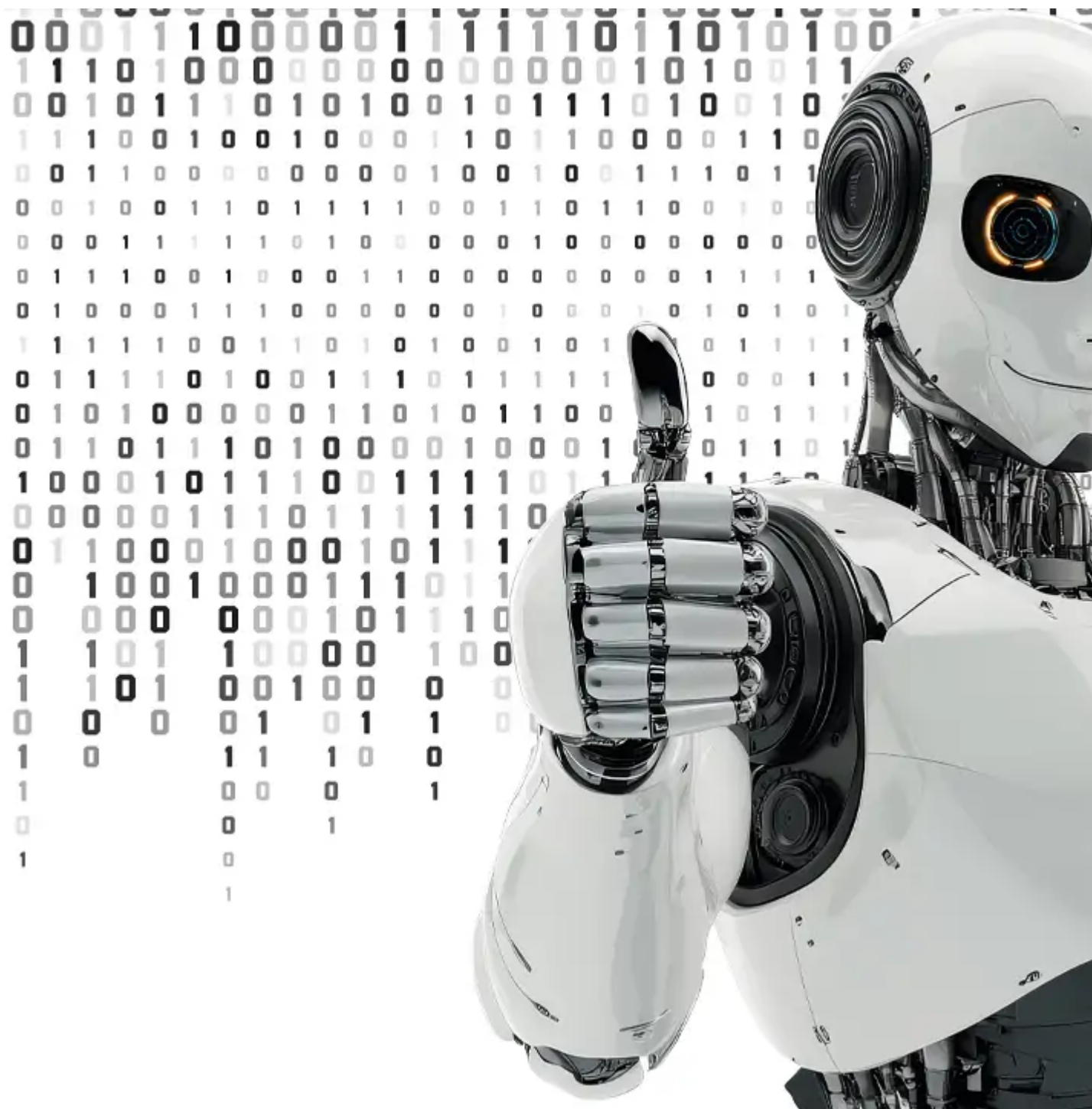


A Short Story: The ReboundBot [B1]

Sostituire il proprio ex con una versione migliorata: è l'idea rivoluzionaria di Lexi. Ma le cose non andranno come aveva immaginato.



Lexy watched as ten thousand new DomBots V27 came to life on the factory floor of XpertAI. They were [facing](#) ten thousand DomBots V26 and immediately began

their first task — dismantling their predecessors, whose hardware and software would be recycled and reused. “Oh, the poor bots,” said Lexy’s [grand](#)mother, who was touring the factory before they went to lunch together. She was fascinated, if a little horrified, by Lexy’s role as XpertAI [CEO](#). “Don’t you feel bad for them?” Lexy [rolled her eyes](#). Her [grand](#)mother was a typical Gen Z-er. She viewed humanoid AI as more human than AI, convinced they’d eventually become [self-aware](#) and replace humanity. “No, [Gran](#),” she said. “They’re machines, not [sentient beings](#). Every new generation is programmed with the New and [Improved](#) Directive, to [dispose](#) of the AI it’s replacing in a sustainable way. At least we’re not [dumping](#) old tech in [landfills](#), like in your day.” “I’d suppose that’s true,” conceded [Gran](#). The world had changed since [Gran](#) was young, and now humanoid AIs, such as DomBots — programmed to do domestic tasks — were a part of everyday life. “You have to meet my creation,” said Lexy, when she and [Gran](#) returned to her office. She activated the generic-looking humanoid AI by her desk. Its face illuminated with a smile. “Oh, hello, Mrs. Walters,” it said, in an Irish accent. “And how is my favourite [grand](#) lady today?” “Remind you of anyone?” asked Lexy. Her [grand](#)mother looked surprised. “It’s... Ooooh, but it can’t be.” “But it is. Meet the New and [Improved](#) Brian.” Brian had been Lexy’s boyfriend for four years. She’d been devastated when they’d broken up. But then the break-up had inspired her to create the ReboundBot, an AI to help people [rebound](#) and recover from past relationships. She’d insisted on doing all the programming herself, ignoring objections from her subordinates. She was [confident](#) that, as the company’s [CEO](#), she had the necessary programming skills, and [besides](#), this was her personal project. She had programmed the ReboundBot as the New and [Improved](#) Brian, using all available material about her ex-boyfriend, from school records to professional bios to audio and video recordings. The ReboundBot had even visited Brian at home, [in the guise of](#) a DeliveryBot, to perfect its imitation of him. “I’m going to test it out for a month before we [release](#) it to the world,” she said. “Oh dear, I’m not sure that’s such a good idea,” said [Gran](#). “What if you fall in love with him?” This was another crazy Gen Z idea, that AI would replace humans in relationships. Certainly, there was a niche market for RomBots, but most people wanted relationships with other humans, not machines. “It’s not a ‘him’, it’s an ‘it’,” she said. “And I’m not going to fall in love with it. I just want [closure](#), that’s all.” Lexy’s test of the ReboundBot, or the BrianBot, as she named it, was a complete success. The BrianBot had all the same characteristics as Brian, and all the same irritating habits. Those habits had been the cause of many [arguments](#) between them, and still were. However, the BrianBot was programmed to respond to Lexy’s use of the code word ‘[Whatever](#)’ by conceding in any [argument](#). “I’ve told you a million times not to put the [empty milk carton](#) back in the fridge,” she said to the BrianBot one morning, initiating a common [argument](#). “[What’s the big deal?](#)” the BrianBot responded. “Just order a new one.” “I need it now, so I can have cereal for breakfast.” “You can’t have toast instead?” “No, I can’t... [Whatever](#)!” At the mention of the code word, the BrianBot conceded. “You’re right. It was inconsiderate of me. I’m so sorry.” Of course, she

and the BrianBot didn't [argue](#) all the time. Most of the time, the AI was kind and considerate, just as Brian had been, reminding her why she'd been with him for four years. "It helped me to see our relationship in a more balanced way," said Lexy, in her promotional video for the ReboundBot a few weeks later, "to appreciate the good times and accept the bad times, and eventually to find [closure](#). And I know it can help you, too." The ReboundBot was an immediate success, selling ten thousand units in its first week. Before deactivating the BrianBot, Lexy took it to meet the real Brian. She thought he'd find it [amusing](#), and [besides](#), she wanted an opportunity to resolve things with him. She knocked on his door but got no response. "You looking for the Irish guy?" asked an elderly neighbour. "I haven't seen him in weeks. Perhaps he's gone back to Ireland." "Perhaps," said Lexy. "Or perhaps he's ignoring me," she said to the BrianBot as they left. "Who?" asked the BrianBot. "Brian." "But I am Brian." "Well, no, you're an AI." "But Brian was an AI." "No, Brian is human..." Lexy froze. "Why did you say 'was'?" "Was. [Past tense](#). I am the New and [Improved](#) Brian." "Oh, my God. Oh, no. Oh, God, no!" Lexy realised with horror the fatal [flaw](#) in her programming. AI was incapable of [harming](#) humans. But she had programmed the ReboundBot to perceive the human it was replacing as AI, which meant the BrianBot would have dismantled its predecessor when it visited him. She imagined the horror in Brian's apartment, and then the horror being inflicted by the ten thousand ReboundBots [release](#)d into the world. It was every Gen Z fear realised, and it was all her [fault](#).

Glossary

- **amusing** = divertente
- **flaw** = difetto
- **Gran** = nonna
- **sentient beings** = esseri senzienti
- **dumping** = buttare
- **grand** = splendida
- **rebound** = riprendersi
- **closure** = voltare pagina
- **empty milk carton** = cartone del latte vuoto
- **Past tense** = tempo passato
- **CEO** = amministratrice delegata (Chief Executive Officer)
- **dispose** = disfarsi
- **besides** = inoltre
- **fault** = colpa
- **in the guise of** = nei panni di
- **rolled her eyes** = alzare gli occhi al cielo
- **self-aware** = consapevoli di sé
- **landfills** = discariche
- **Whatever** = vabbè, come vuoi
- **argue** = discutere
- **harming** = fare male
- **facing** = affrontare
- **Improved** = migliorare
- **confident** = sicura
- **release** = lanciare
- **argument** = litigio
- **What's the big deal?** = qual è il problema?